Focus marking in Ìkálẹ̀ and the Final-Over-Final Condition

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Abstract

This paper investigates ex-situ focalization in Ìkálẹ̀, a Yorùbá dialect of Nigeria, which appears to violate the Final-Over-Final Condition (FOFC) due to its clause-final morphological focus marking. Starting with a description of focus realization in the language, I propose that Ìkálẹ̀'s ex-situ focus particle realizes a head-final FocP, which dominates a head-initial TP. I argue that such a FOFC-violating structure is best analyzed using the phase-based approach to FOFC's enforcement (à la Richards 2016, Erlewine 2017), rather than through extended projections. I further discuss two prominent alternative approaches to FOFC, (Biberauer et al.'s (2014) &Biberauer's (2017a) asymmetric approach and Zeijlstra's (2023) symmetric approach), and the potential challenges they face. I then propose that the analysis may be extended to two other Benue-Congo languages (Igede and Nupe) and two other dialects of Yorùbá (Oǹdó and Òkìtìpupa) with similar ex-situ clause-final morphological focus marking.

Keywords: Ex-situ focus, FOFC, phases, spell-out, head-finality, extended projections

1 Introduction

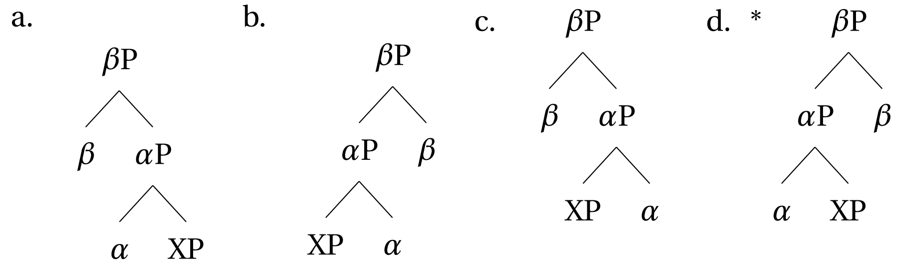
The Final-Over-Final Condition (henceforth FOFC) has been proposed to be a universal structure-building condition, which requires that only a head-final phrase can dominate a head-final phrase $[_{XP}\ [_{YP}\ \text{ZP}\ \mathbf{Y}]\ \mathbf{X}]$. Cross-linguistic studies have shown that this condition holds in many languages (cf. Holmberg 2000, Biberauer et al. 2008, Biberauer and Sheehan 2012, Sheehan et al. 2017, i.a.). FOFC's generalization is given in (1)

(1) **The Final-over-Final Condition (FOFC)**:
A head-final phrase αP cannot dominate a head-initial phrase βP, where α and β are heads in the same *Extended Projection* (EP).

(Biberauer et al. 2014, p.206)

The generalization in (1) highlights two things: (a) FOFC conditions structure building, and (b) FOFC holds within a certain domain, i.e., FOFC does not apply to the entire utterance. Based on the first part in the FOFC generalization in (1), only the structures in (2a) - (2c) are possible. (2d) is predicted to be ungrammatical because we have a head-final phrase dominating a head-initial phrase. In other words, any time we have a head-final phrase dominating a phrase, the latter must be head-final as well.

(2)



The statement in (1) suggests that FOFC does not hold across an entire sentence. The domain of FOFC application is constrained to an extended projection. To make this clearer, consider the German example in (3) (Biberauer et al. 2008, p.99, ex. 12a). In (3), a head-final VP dominates a head-initial DP. Going by only the first part of (1), we might expect such a construction to violate FOFC. However, this is a grammatical sentence in German.

(3) Johann hat [$_{VP}$ [$_{DP}$ den Mann] gesehen].
John has DEF man seen
'John has seen the man.'

(from Biberauer et al. 2008, p.99)

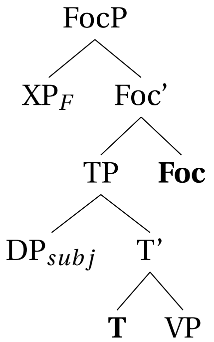
The reason for the grammaticality is due to the second part of the FOFC generalization above: FOFC holds within an extended projection (Grimshaw 2000, 2005). According to Grimshaw (2000, 2005), syntactic categories can be grouped into extended projections which are motivated by the systematic relationships or dependencies observed among those syntactic categories. So, the verbal extended projection includes *VP*, *vP*, *TP* and *CP*, while the nominal extended projection includes *NP*, *DP*, *PP*, and by extension, any other projection within the nominal domain. The idea is that while the phrases within the verbal extended projection all bear [+V], the phrases within the nominal extended projection all bear [+N]. Therefore, going back to the German example in (3), the VP and the DP belong to different extended projections. So, FOFC is not violated. This explains the grammaticality of such structures.

Importantly, the range of constructions or domains subjected to FOFC has expanded over the years. Although FOFC was first postulated based on the auxiliary-verb ordering in Finnish (Holmberg 2000), it has since been argued to constrain word order in other domains, such as the nominal domain (Roberts 2017), adverbs (Sheehan 2017), adpositions (Biberauer 2017b), extrapositions (Biberauer and Sheehan 2012), clause-final particles (in Mandarin Chinese) (Erlewine 2017), and VP-nominalization (in West African languages) (Hein and Murphy 2022).

This paper extends the coverage of FOFC to morphosyntactic focus marking.[1] The paper presents novel data from Ìkálẹ̀, a southwestern dialect of Yorùbá (Benue-Congo, Nigeria). Focus marking in Ìkálẹ̀ involves a clause-final morphological marking plus syntactic re-ordering (4b). The presence of such a clause-final focus marker, which I argue to occupy the head of a clause-peripheral FocP, results in a head-final phrase dominating a head-initial phrase (TP) (5). The construction appears to constitute an exception to FOFC (see (1)).

(4) a. Who did Adé see?
b. [Tolú]$_F$ Adé rí __ *(**rín**).
T. A. see FOC
'Adé saw TOLÚ'.

(5)



There have been, at least, three different approaches to the treatment of apparently FOFC-violating clause-final particles (CFPs henceforth). The first approach argues that FOFC-violating CFPs are in fact not a threat to FOFC because they can (a) have double or multiple function within a language, (b) be optional in their use, or (c) be acategorial, i.e., combined with different XPs, which calls into question their categorial status (see Biberauer et al. 2014, Biberauer 2017a, a.o.). The second approach is phase-based.[2] This approach proposes that FOFC only applies within the Spell-Out domain of a phase, which excludes the phase edge (the specifier and

[1] See Biberauer et al. (2014), Biberauer (2017a), Zeijlstra (2023), a.o., for discussions on clause-final particles and FOFC, which the Ìkálẹ̀ case can be classified under.

[2] I use the terms 'phase-based approach' and 'Spell-Out approach' interchangeably throughout this paper.

the head of the phase). Clause-final particles are on the edge of a phase, which explains why they seem to be an exception to FOFC. Their domain (complement) has undergone spell-out. This is the view by Erlewine (2017) for Sentence Final Particles (SFPs) in Mandarin Chinese whereby "FOFC holds only within individual Spell-Out domains" (see also Richards 2016). The third approach to FOFC-violating CFPs is by Zeijlstra (2023) who argues that, contrary to Biberauer and others, FOFC and its counter-examples can be uniformly accounted for by an independent ban on rightward movement.[3]

In this study, I argue that the phase-based approach to the characterization of FOFC domains best explains the clause-final ex-situ focus marking in Ìkálẹ̀. In contrast, I show that the clause-final focus particle in Ìkálẹ̀ is not *acategorial* like most of the particles discussed by Biberauer and Sheehan (2012), Biberauer et al. (2014), Biberauer (2017a), Sheehan (2017), among others. We need more than just an explanation that is based on the categorial properties of such particles. We need a structural condition that predicts where such particles can occur, and why they usually do not violate FOFC.

For the sections that follow, section 2 provides a brief background on the syntax of Ìkálẹ̀ and then describes the ex-situ focalization strategy which produces FOFC-violating structures. Section 3 proposes an analysis which is phase-based, characterizing the FOFC domain as the Spell-Out domain of a phase (cf. Phase Impenetrability Condition (PIC)). Afterwards, in section 4, two alternative approaches are discussed, including the challenges they face. In addition, some concerns raised with respect to the phase-based approach to FOFC are addressed. In section 5, I show how clause-final ex-situ focus marking may be derived based on Kayne's (1994) antisymmetric syntax. I, however, highlight a few challenges for using such an approach to derive ex-situ focus in Ìkálẹ̀. Next, in section 6, I discuss how the proposal may be extended to two other Benue-Congo languages (Igede and Nupe) and two other dialects of Yorùbá (Oǹdó and Òkìtìpupa) with similar clause-final morphological focus marking. Section 7 concludes the paper.

2 Background on Ìkálẹ̀ and its Focus realization

2.1 Basic syntax of Ìkálẹ̀

Although Standard Yorùbá has received much attention in the literature, its different dialects are mostly understudied. Often, the basic assumption is that the dialects of Yorùbá behave the same way as the standard variety. However, studies on the different dialects of the language have proven that

[3]See section 4 for further discussion of the first and third approaches.

this assumption can be misleading (Akinkugbe 1976, Adeoye 1979, Ajíbóyè 2001, Sheba 2007, Adeniyi 2010, Akintoye 2020, i.a.).[4] Based on Adeniyi's (2010) grouping of Yorùbá dialects, Ìkálẹ̀ falls within the southeastern dialects of Yorùbá.[5] The Ìkálẹ̀ dialect of Yorùbá is spoken predominantly in Oǹdó state, Nigeria.

Structurally, Ìkálẹ̀ is SVO in its word order (6), just like the standard variety (cf. Aremu 2021, 2025). Preliminary work suggests that Ìkálẹ̀, just like Standard Yorùbá, has three level tones: high, mid and low. As far as I know, tone does not play any significant role in the present study and analysis. But I will mark the tones on the words for the sake of the orthography and correct pronunciation.[6]

(6) Adé áa pa ekún nẹ̀.
A. FUT kill rat DEF
'Adé will kill the rat.'

2.2 Focus marking in Ìkálẹ̀: an apparent exception to FOFC

In Ìkálẹ̀, focus may be realized in-situ or ex-situ. The in-situ strategy does not involve any overt focus marking, in the sense of morphological focus marking or syntactic re-ordering. It shares the same structure as a normal declarative sentence. This is exemplified with the in-situ object focus in (7b). The only way to recognize the logical focus is through the current question (7a)[7] (cf. Roberts 1996, 2004, Beaver and Clark 2008, Velleman and Beaver 2016).

(7) **Object question and in-situ answer**

a. Nèé Adé rí?
who A. see
'Who did Adé see?'

b. Adé rí [Tolú]$_F$.
A. see T.
'Adé saw TOLÙ.'

The focus strategy that is of interest to us here is the ex-situ strategy. This involves both the morphological focus marking with the particle *rín* and the syntactic displacement of the focus constituent to the left periph-

[4] For the history and migration account of Ìkálẹ̀ speakers, see Sheba (2007).

[5] The data used in this study are from a series of interviews with my language consultants: Mr. Ayomide Akinlalu and his father, Pa Akinlalu. I am grateful to them.

[6] For a study on the phonology of Ìkálẹ̀, see Ajebiewe (1992).

[7] Just like the focused answer, in-situ *wh*-question is possible as well. However, *wh*-questions do not require the focus marker *rín* in the language. This may suggest a dichotomy between focused versus non-focused *wh*-question formation. See Aboh (2007) for a discussion.

ery of the clause. For example, the same object *wh*-question as before can be answered by fronting the object to the left periphery in addition to the presence of *rín* in the clause-final position (8b). If the focus is in-situ, *rín* cannot occur (8c).

(8) ***Rín*-marking with ex-situ focus**

a. Nèé Adé rí?
who A. see
'Who did Adé see?'

b. [Tolú]$_F$ Adé rí __ *(**rín**).
T. A. see FOC
'Adé saw TOLÙ'.

c. Adé rí [Tolú]$_F$ (***rín**).
A. see T.
'Adé saw TOLÚ.'

Similarly, in long distance constructions, when the embedded object is fronted to the left periphery of the matrix clause, as in (9b), *rín* occurs clause-finally. However, if the embedded object focus remains in-situ, *rín* is absent.

(9) **Embedded object focus**

a. Nèé Adé fọ̀ fi Bọ́lá rí ní ọjà?
who A. say COMP B. see at market
'Who did Adé say that Bọ́lá saw at the market?'

b. [Tolú]$_F$ Adé fọ̀ fi Bọ́lá rí __ ní ọjà *(**rín**).
T. A. say COMP B. see at market FOC
'Adé said that Bọ́lá saw TOLÚ at the market.'

c. Adé fọ̀ fi Bọ́lá rí [Tolú]$_F$ ní ọjà (***rín**).
A. say COMP B. see T. at market FOC
'Adé said that Bọ́lá saw TOLU at the market.'

The same pattern is observed with respect to local and non-local subject focus. The only difference here is the presence of a resumptive pronoun *ó* when the subject focus is ex-situ (cf. (10b) & (11b)). Both the resumptive pronoun and *rín* do not occur in in-situ local and long-distance subject focus ((10c) & (11c)). In summary, *rín* is obligatorily associated with ex-situ focus.

(10) **Local subject focus**

a. Nọ̀ọ́ jẹ ejíjẹ nẹ̀?
who eat food DEF
'Who ate the food?'

b. [Adé]$_F$ *(ó) jẹ ejíjẹ nẹ̀ *(**rín**).
A. RP eat food DEF FOC
'ADÉ ate the food.'

c. [Adé]$_F$ (*ó) jẹ ejíjẹ nẹ̀ (***rín**).
A. eat food DEF
'ADÉ ate the food.'

(11) **Embedded subject focus**

a. Nẹ̀ẹ́ Adé fọ̀ fi *(ó) fẹ́ràn Tolú?
who A. say COMP RP love Tolú
'Who did Adé say loves Tolú?'

b. [Bọ́lá]$_F$ Adé fọ̀ fi *(ó) fẹ́ràn Tolú *(**rín**).
B. A. say COMP RP love T. FOC
'Adé said that BỌ́LÁ loves Tolú.'

c. Adé fọ̀ fi [Bọ́lá]$_F$ (*ó) fẹ́ràn Tolú (***rín**).
A. say COMP B. love T.
'Adé said that BỌ́LÁ loves Tolú.'

The data I have presented so far does not immediately indicate the actual structural position of *rín*. Based on the data here, *rín* could, for example, be at the CP periphery (12a) or the vP periphery (12b). In the next section, I argue that *rín* is higher than the vP periphery; it is in the clausal periphery.

(12) a. [$_{FOCP}$ DP [$_{TP}$ [$_{vP}$ [$_{VP}$ __]]]**rín**]
b. [$_{CP}$ DP [$_{TP}$ [$_{FOCP}$ [$_{vP}$ [$_{VP}$ __]]**rín**]]]

2.3 Arguing for the structural position of rín

The first evidence for a CP-*rín* comes from fragment answers like the subject focus in (13b), which answers the *wh*-question in (13a). In the fragment answer, the TP is elided (see e.g. Merchant 2005). If *rín's* structural position is clause-internal, i.e. at the vP periphery, then it is unclear why it is not elided. This can only be because *rín* was never inside of the ellipsis site (the TP) in the first place. The fragment answer had moved to its Spec.

(13) **Subject fragment answer with *rín***

a. Nọ̀ọ́ jẹ ejíjẹ nẹ̀?
who eat food DEF
'Who ate the food?'

b. [$_{CP}$ [Adé]$_F$ ~~[TP *(ó) jẹ ejíjẹ nẹ̀]~~ *(**rín**)].
A. FOC
'ADÉ ~~ate the food~~.'

The same explanation applies to the object fragment answer in (14b). *Rín* survives TP ellipsis, and hosts the fragment answer in its Spec.

(14) **Object fragment answer with *rín***

a. Nèé Adé rí?
who A. see
'Who did Adé see?'

b. [CP [Tolú]F ~~[TP Adé rí ___]~~ *(**rín**)].
T. FOC
'TOLÚ ~~Adé saw~~.'

An argument for CP-*rín* appears to come from the distribution of the focus marking itself. If *rín* occupies a low position, let's say the vP periphery, then this would predict that *rín* would only appear with local objects and maybe long-distance movement, but never with local subject focus movement. This is because the local subject's focus movement does not pass through vP.[8] It follows its normal derivation up to TP. However, we have seen that *rín*-marking is not excluded in local subject movement. It appears in all ex-situ focus contexts; whether subject or non-subject, local or non-local. This can only mean that *rín* is high enough to mark ex-situ focus subject.

Additional comparative evidence comes from focus marking in Standard Yorùbá. In Standard Yorùbá, the morphological focus marker *ni* immediately follows the fronted focus phrase. Consider the ex-situ object focus and subject focus data below. The word order with respect to the subject shows that the focus marker *ni* is higher than the TP. I assume the same high structural position for *rín* in Ìkálẹ̀; only that in the latter, the focus marker appears clause-finally.

(15) a. [Iṣu]F **ni** Adé jẹ __.
yam FOC A. eat
'Adé ate YAM'

b. [Adé]F **ni** *(ó) jẹ iṣu.
A. FOC RP eat yam
'ADÉ ate yam.'

Based on these pieces of evidence, I conclude that the clause-final focus marker *rín* occupies a high position in the clause, above the TP. I assume this position to be the head of a clause-peripheral FocP.

[8]Unaccusative cases do not pose a challenge for the discussion here because the movement from a complement of V position to Spec,TP is an A-movement. So, it is different from A'-movement that we are treating here. Thus, before an unaccusative subject is focalized, it must have gone through A-movement to Spec,TP before undergoing A'-movement. Otherwise, we would be dealing with a case of an improper movement (Chomsky 1973) if we assume that the unaccusative subject A'-moves through vP, and then A-moves to Spec,TP.

3 A proposed analysis for *rín*-marking and FOFC

In what follows, I argue that the characterization of FOFC's domain of application, based on the extended projection, cannot account for the observed ex-situ focus construction in Ìkálẹ̀. Instead, I propose a phase-based characterization of FOFC's enforcement for ex-situ focus in Ìkálẹ̀ following Richards (2016) and Erlewine (2017).

Similar to the German example in (3), we have seen that in Ìkálẹ̀, what might otherwise be a FOFC violation is instead grammatical. The repeated direct object ex-situ focus construction in (16) (repeated from (8b) above) shows that *rín*, a head-final element dominates a head-initial TP phrase. The CP peripheral position of *rín* has already been established based on the various tests in §2.3. The ex-situ focus structure is proposed below.

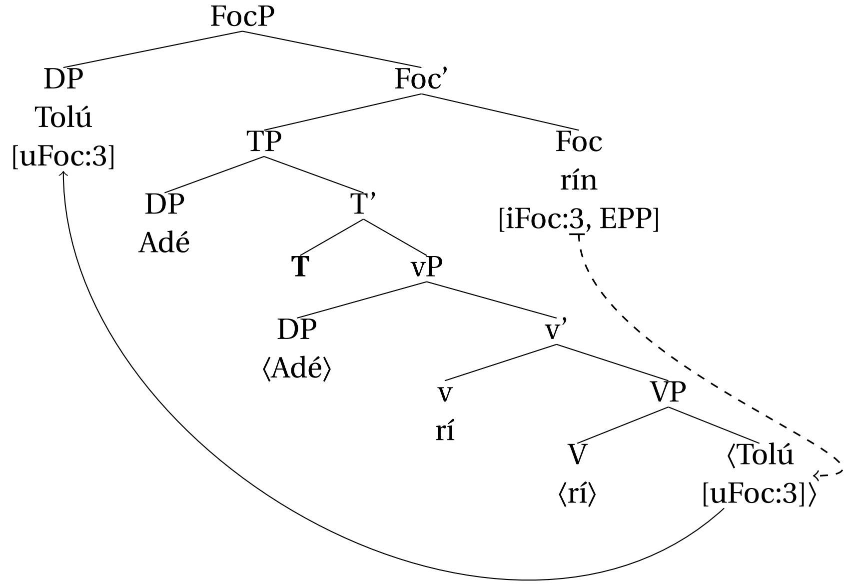
(16) [Tolú]$_F$ Adé rí __ *(**rín**).
T. A. see FOC
'Adé saw TOLÙ'.

I assume the structure in (17) where *rín* heads a FocP (following Rizzi's (1997) split-CP hypothesis) above the TP. The focus head starts out as an unvalued interpretable feature, and agrees with the focus constituent that possesses a valued but uninterpretable focus feature.[9] The unvalued feature on Foc causes it to probe for valuation. After it has been valued, the goal of the agreement operation (here the object) moves to Spec,FocP to satisfy the EPP on Foc.

Looking at (17), we have a structure where a head-final phrase, FocP, dominates a head-initial phrase, TP. This is a potential FOFC-violating structure. However, we have seen from the data presented above that such a structure is grammatical.

[9]The number *3* in the feature specification is only an arbitrary index which represent feature valuation, and the same index between the probe (Foc) and the goal (object focus) means a shared feature value. Nothing hinges on the number. It can as well be 1,2, ..., or even *val*.

(17) **Ìkálẹ̀ ex-situ focus structure**



Unlike the case of the German example in (3), the characterization of FOFC domains based on extended projections cannot account for what we observe in ex-situ focus constructions in Ìkálẹ̀. The idea is that since FocP is one of the phrases within the split-CP (cf. Rizzi 1997), it is also part of the verbal extended projection. In fact, nothing hinges on the use of FocP instead of CP in our structure in (17). FocP and TP belong to the same extended projection, and we expect FOFC to hold between them under such circumstances. The fact that FOFC is violated raises the question of how to account for the grammaticality of such a structure. This is where the phase-based characterization of FOFC domain comes in.

Richards (2016) and Erlewine (2017) argue that the domain of FOFC application can be characterized by Spell-Out, instead of by extended projection. The characterization of FOFC domain based on (18) allows for an inclusive treatment of apparently FOFC-violating structures, like the ex-situ focus construction in Ìkálẹ̀.

(18) *Phasehood characterization of FOFC domains*
FOFC holds only within individual Spell-out domains.

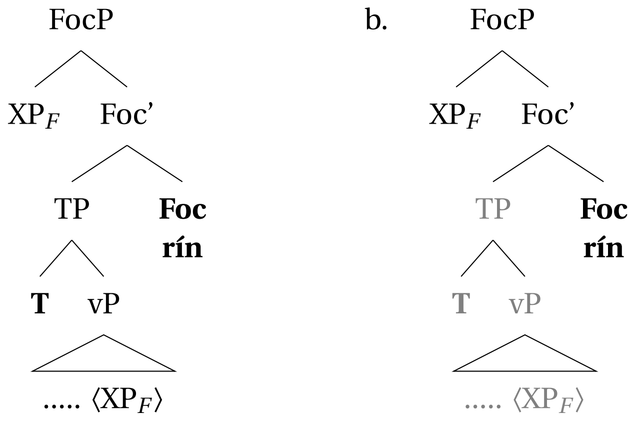
(adapted & modified from Erlewine 2017, p.67)

Similar to Erlewine's (2017) proposal for sentence final particles in Mandarin Chinese, the assumption here is that the head of FocP in ex-situ focus constructions, corresponds to the CP-level.[10] The head initial TP is then the

[10]The idea here is compatible with at least two views of what counts as phasal domains. First is the traditional view which counts both the CP and the little vP as phases (Chomsky 1986, 2000, 2001, 2008, i.a.). The second is the contextual view to phases where phases are

complement of the phase head, and therefore the Spell-Out domain of the phase. This is illustrated with the structures in (19).

(19) a. b.



Based on the traditional view of phases by Chomsky (2000, 2001), as in the PIC in (20), the Foc head and its Spec are the phase edge. They are not spelled-out until the merging of a higher phase; in a cyclic Spell-Out manner or at the end of the entire derivation (see Grohmann et al. 2017, on what happens to the very top of the tree in phasal Spell-Out theory).

(20) **Strong Phase Impenetrability Condition** (Chomsky 2000, p.108)
In phase α with head H, the domain of H is not accessible to operations outside of α, only H and its edge are accessible to such operations.

Since the FOFC domain is characterized by the Spell-Out domain, the structure in (19b) shows how head-initial TP is within this Spell-Out domain and is no longer accessible to outside operations. This explains why such a structure which may appear to violate FOFC, does not. It also shows why such head-final particles often appear at the periphery of the clause (cf. Erlewine 2017). This is only expected based on the theory of phasal Spell-Out.[11] In summary, what we have here is a situation where the head-final FocP and the head-initial TP belong to different FOFC domains which are characterized by Spell-Out domains (cf. (18)).

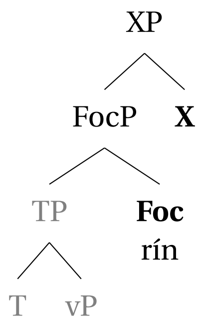
After FocP is built, any potential head that is merged with FocP would always be FOFC-complaint. It does not matter whether it is head-final or head-initial. If the merged head is head-final, we would have a harmonic final-over-final structure (21a), and if it is head initial, we would have a

contextually determined (Bošković 2005, 2014, Gallego and Uriagereka 2007, Den Dikken 2007, Takahashi 2011, i.a.)

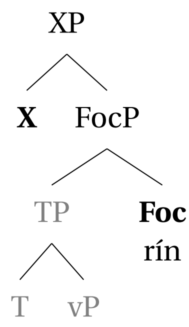
[11]See Erlewine (2017, pp.68-69) and Erlewine (2023) (on Singlish) for a proposal on how to deal with cases where FOFC applies across phase boundaries, like the auxiliary construction in Finnish (cf. Holmberg 2000).

FOFC-compliant disharmonic initial-over-final structure (21b).

(21) a. **Harmonic F-over-F**



b. **Disharmonic I-over-F**



4 Alternative analyses to FOFC and Clause-Final Particles (CFPs)

In this section, I discuss two alternative analyses, which have been proposed to account for CFPs and theire apparent FOFC violations. The first concerns Biberauer et al.'s (2014) acategorial explanation for the exemption of clause-final particles in FOFC. The second alternative analysis is Zeijlstra's (2023) symmetric analysis. I discuss a few challenges that these alternative analyses face, both generally and with respect to *rín* focus marking in Ìkálẹ̀. Lastly, I highlight the issues that have been raised in the literature concerning the Spell-Out approach to FOFC, and then suggest solutions to these issues.

4.1 Biberauer et al.'s (2014) asymmetric analysis and 'acategorial' status of CFPs

I will start with a discussion of Biberauer et al.'s (2014) general proposal for accounting for FOFC, and then discuss their idea for specifically accounting for FOFC-violating clause-final particles. In each case, I highlight some challenges that their proposal faces.

4.1.1 Biberauer et al.'s (2014) proposal for FOFC analysis

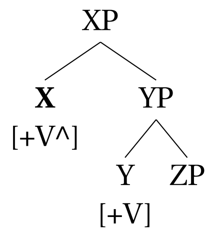
The original analysis of FOFC by Biberauer et al. (2014) is weaved within the broader anti-symmetric structure-building approach (cf. Linear Correspondence Axiom (LCA)) (Kayne 1994). In this approach, a head-final phrase is said to be derived from the movement of its complement to its Spec position. Biberauer et al. (2014) formally encodes this operation by a movement caret (^) on the head in question. This requires that the Spec of the head with the movement ^ be filled. Importantly, such a movement-triggering feature is absent on the head of a head-initial phrase. It is also assumed that this formal feature is included, and in a way feeds on the different types of feature(s) on a head. So if ^ associates with a ϕ-feature, it triggers A-movement. If it associates with edge feature on a head, it triggers A'-movement. Importantly, if it associates with a categorial feature [±V], it triggers the complement of V to Spec,VP movement. Biberauer et al. (2014) assume the formal statement in (22) for FOFC constraint.

(22) **The Final-over-Final Constraint (formal statement)**
If a head α_i in the extended projection EP of a lexical head L, EP(L), has ^ associated with its [±V]-feature, then so does α_{i+1}, where α_{i+1} is c-selected by α_i in EP(L).

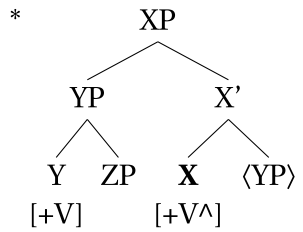
(adapted from Biberauer et al. 2014, p.210)

The idea here is that in an extended projection spine, if a higher head X with ^ c-selects a [±V] head Y, then X must have inherited ^ from the lower head Y. In other words, a higher head X in an extended projection cannot possess ^ without Y possessing the same. This is because the categorial [±V] feature is inherited and iterated by succeeding heads in the extended projection, and the movement feature ^ is dependent on the categorial feature, since it is not a categorial feature itself (and thus cannot be selected alone). Applying this assumption to the extended verbal domain, the structure in (23a) is said to be ruled out because we have a c-selecting head X with [+V^], but the selected head Y lacking ^. This will therefore produce the FOFC-violating structure in (23b), whereby a head-final phrase XP immediately dominates a head-initial phrase YP. This derives the FOFC pattern because the higher head has no way of inheriting ^ without the lower head having it.

(23) a.



b. **FOFC-violating F-over-I structure**

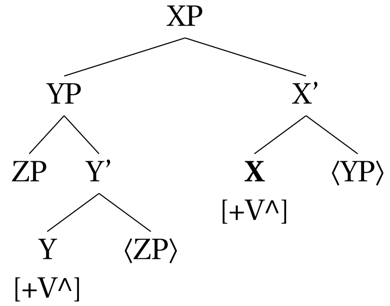


(from Biberauer et al. 2014, p.212)

On the other hand, if Y has the movement feature [+V^], then ZP would have moved to Spec,YP, making Y head-final before YP's movement to Spec,XP, see (24). This, therefore, would have resulted in a FOFC-compliant structure, i.e., head-final X over head-final Y.[12]

[12] Biberauer et al. (2014) associates the locality condition of the c-selectional pattern of their analysis with the Relativized Minimality approach (Rizzi 2001).

(24) **FOFC-compliant F-over-F structure**



While Biberauer et al.'s (2014) analysis is quite innovative, it faces certain challenges that besets the anti-symmetric structure-building approach as a whole. The first notable challenge is the Comp-to-Spec anti-locality constraint, where complements are restricted from moving to the Spec of their selecting heads (see Abels 2003, Grohmann 2003, a.o.). This is motivated by the idea that a head can already satisfy its property on its complement under the sisterhood condition (cf. Chomsky 1965, Adger 2003) even without the complements movement to the Spec of the head. Another problem for this approach, according to Zeijlstra (2023), is that what really motivates the assumption that the movement diacritic ^ can only start out on lexical heads. What forbids the same from starting out on a functional head? In fact, we know that movement-triggering features such as EPP are usually specified on functional heads for both A-movement and A'-movement. See Zeijlstra (2023) for further criticisms of this approach.

4.1.2 Biberauer et al. (2014) and Biberauer's (2017a) 'acategorial' analysis of CFPs

Following Biberauer et al. (2014) and Biberauer (2017a), an approach to clause-final particles that appear to produce FOFC-violating structures is that they are *acategorial.* In other words, they behave differently from proper categorial elements like nouns and verbs; they are "categorially deficient" according to Biberauer et al. (2009, p.712). Therefore the proposal is that such particles do not interact with the rest of the clausal spine, and therefore FOFC does not apply to them. More concretely, such particles are said to not be c-selected by another head because they are "always the last of the elements in a given lexical array to be merged" (Biberauer et al. 2014, p.213). Therefore, they predictably occupy peripheral positions.

One of the properties of these particles, according to Biberauer (2017a) is that they are optional in their occurrence. For example, the question particle *ma* in Mandarin Chinese is said to be optional because prosody/intonation can indicate the interrogative force of the sentence (i.e Force^{o} can be null) (25). Thus *ma* only optionally doubles or affirm the interrogative force (cf. Biberauer et al. 2014).

(25) Hongjian xihuan zhe ben shu (**ma**)?
Hongjian like this CL book Q
'Does Hongjian like this book?'

(Biberauer et al. (2014, p.199) citing Li (2006, p.13))

The idea of optional doubling of some clause-final particles needs further investigation because, for example, the so-called doubling of intonation and particle may after all be playing distinct roles, as in the confirmational 'eh' sentence final particle in English with a rising intonation. See the biased question in (26) (where the question mark *?* doubles as the rising contour sign/marker). Wiltschko and Heim (2016) use such data to argue for an Interactional Spine Hypothesis (ISH), where both the intonation and the particle itself occupy distinct heads in the functional layers above the propositional CP.[13] In their interactional spine analysis, while the lexical form *eh* is associated with a grounding layer (GroundP) where the speakers attitude (to *p*) is encoded, the rising intonation is associated with a higher response layer (RespP), where the call on addressee (CoA) (to confirm *p*) is encoded, (27).[14]

(26) You bought a car, eh?

(27) $[_{\text{RespP}}$ / $[_{\text{GroundP}}$ eh $[_{\text{CP}}$ ...]]]

Another example is Medumba (Grassfields' Bamileke Bantu language), where question particles seem to be doubled (periphrastically), only to be marking distinct speaker-addressee-oriented interpretation, (28). According to Heim et al. (2014), *kʉla* expresses the speaker's attitude (i.e., believe) towards *p*, and *a* expresses the call on addressee to confirm this believe (see also Wiltschko and Heim 2016).

(28) **Kʉla** u ɣʉ ʙʉ swə **a**?
PRT 2sg have dog new Q
'You have a new dog, eh?' (from Heim et al. 2014, p.12, ex.26)

The point being made here is that the claim that certain particles are optional or mere concord items may prove to be untrue with further investigation. If this is the case, then such particles are indeed candidates for counter-exemplifying FOFC.[15]

[13]See Wiltschko (2021) for a full discussion of this approach.

[14]It is important to point out here that Wiltschko and Heim (2016) do not commit themselves to whether such heads are to the left or to the right. See Heim et al. (2014) for more discussion.

[15]In fact, a recent dissertation by Xu (2025) argues for fixed functional positions and hierarchy for some Chinese Sentence Final Particles, which is aimed at supporting the different functional projections proposed by ISH. This is maybe an evidence for their categorial

Additionally, some (subclausal) particles may combine with different category XPs (see Sheehan 2017, ch.9, § 9.2.4). This is typical of the adfocal exclusive focus sensitive particle *only* which can adjoin to different categories. Consider the adfocal exclusive particle *nùkàn* in Ìkálẹ̀ in (29). *Nùkàn* can adjoin to a DP (29a), a PP (29b), or even an adverb (29c). Although *only* is traditionally regarded as an adverb, the aforementioned property has been used to support the claim that (adfocal) exclusive particles are acategorial or syncategorematic elements instead (see Bayer 2018, 2020, for discussion).[16]

(29) a. Bọ́lá je [$_{DP}$ usu **nùkàn**] lọ́rí igi láàná.
Bọ́lá eat yam only on tree yesterday
'Bọ́lá ate only YAM on the tree yesterday.

b. Bọ́lá je usu [$_{PP}$ lọ́rí igi **nùkàn**] láàná.
Bọ́lá eat yam on tree only yesterday
'Bọ́lá ate yam only ON the tree yesterday.

c. Bọ́lá je usu lọ́rí igi [$_{AdvP}$ láàná **nùkàn**].
Bọ́lá eat yam on tree yesterday only
'Bọ́lá ate yam on the three only YESTERDAY.'

The idea is that particles such as *nùkàn*, which do not adjoin to specific categories, but are flexible in their adjunction, can be said to be acategorial, and therefore not subject to FOFC.[17]

However, the same cannot be said of *rín* in Ìkálẹ̀, which appears to be strict in its distribution. It only merges with a TP, and appears whenever there is an ex-situ focus. Therefore, the fact that *rín* appears to specifically select a TP, and also triggers focus movement, suggests that it is a head. This is in contrast to the distribution of the exclusive particle *nùkàn* in the same language that do not show such a categorial restriction. Furthermore, some of the properties of the clause-final particles discussed above are not attested with *rín*. It is not optional and does not have any other function in the dialect.

As much as the alternative (acategorial) approach discussed in this section presents interesting facts about the different behaviours of clause-final

status (e.g., an attitudinal category) (cf. Paul 2014, Pan and Paul 2015, Paul and Pan 2017).

[16] Sheehan et al. (2017) discussed other properties of clause-final particles which include the nominalization of such particles, the Malagasy cleft-like structure, etc. (See Sheehan 2017, ch.9 for a discussion on some of these particles)

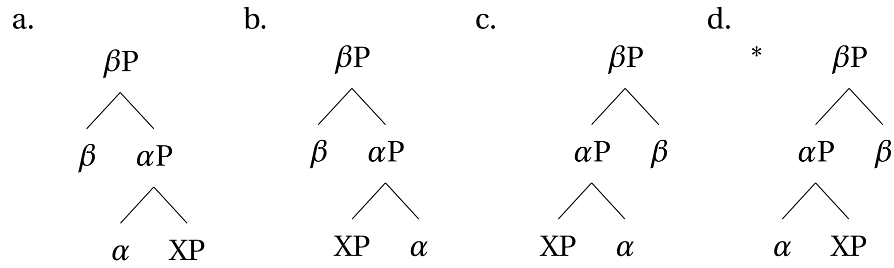
[17] An anonymous reviewer mentioned that acategoriality does not entail optionality and distributional flexibility. While acategoriality might not entirely entail optionality and flexibility, acategorial elements do have such properties. The fact that acategorial elements neither c-select nor project their own phrase supports this. Rather, they extend the projection they are adjoined to. Moreover, Biberauer et al. (2014) appear to use the optionality and flexibility of some clause-final particles to argue for their acategorial status, and therefore their exemption from FOFC.

particles, it does not predict where and when FOFC violation is expected. Such an explanation (at best) only ties the exception of FOFC-violating structures with clause-final particles to the acategorial property of the particles. Even if this is true for some particles, this does not apply to Ìkálẹ̀'s clause-final focus particle *rín*, which I hve argued to be a head of a focus phrase.

4.2 Zeijlstra's (2023) symmetric structural approach

According to Zeijlstra, both FOFC and the counter-examples, which have been raised in earlier analysis, are accounted for by a ban on rightward movement. In other words, they follow from the general leftwardness of movement in syntax. Movement in this case is conditioned by inflectional dependency. Based on the FOFC structures in (30), head movement of α to β in both (30a) and (30b) can be licitly and conveniently derived since these will involve leftward movement. The third configuration (30c) may also be derived if we at least allow string vacuous rightward movement. Yet, even without the rightward movement of the lower head, the result is still a string-adjacent structure in (30c). However, head movement of α to β in (30d) is not possible, and this happens to be the FOFC-violating structure.

(30)



Zeijlstra's approach to FOFC makes two predictions. The first prediction is that as long as the higher head is a movement target for a lower one, the FOFC-violating structure in (30d) is ruled out. The second prediction is that FOFC-violating structures are fine as long as there is no requirement or obligation for movement (from α-β for instance). As a result, this head has to be an independent word, without inflection, and is therefore not a movement target. According to Zeijlstra, much of the FOFC counterexamples involving particles fall within this class.[18] This is why they apparently violate FOFC; i.e., they are not movement targets. In this way, Zeijlstra accounts for the FOFC patterns and the counterexamples to FOFC. (see Zeijlstra 2023, p.194-201 for a more elaborate discussion of the proposal).

While this approach appears to account for the numerous FOFC counterexamples, it faces certain theory-internal challenges. First, this approach

[18]See Biberauer (2017a) and Zeijlstra (2023) for the other counterexamples not mentioned in this paper.

heavily relies on the ban on rightward movement, and as such, any possible instance of rightward movement will most likely cause problems for the approach. Secondly, with this approach, it is not entirely clear what exactly moves in cases where there is an inflectional dependency between α and β. If both are pronounced, it is not clear that head movement really takes place at all. The logic of this account appears to stipulate the presence of head movement in those cases that it wants to rule out as FOFC violations. Lastly, the approach, more or less, treats FOFC as an epiphenomenon of movement directionality. The issue that therefore arises is that, if FOFC is indeed an epiphenomenon of movement directionality, then the burden shifts to explaining why movement is directional in the first place, as well as why FOFC is typologically robust.

I want to end this section by saying that while I maintain the phase-based approach (cyclic spell-out) to Ìkálẹ̀'s sentence-final focus marking, I do not entirely rule out its possible compatibility with the approach discussed in this section. The data might well be analyzed with some refinements of this approach.[19] But until then, I adopt the phase-based approach, as it is more restrictive and makes certain testable predictions, i.e., where and when to expect FOFC-violating structures within the clause.

4.3 Concerns with the phase-based approach

There are a number of concerns that have been raised against the phase-based approach to FOFC that is assumed in this study (see esp. Zeijlstra 2023).[20] The first concern relates to how the phase-based approach will account for the unattested *V-O-Aux order in languages such as Finnish, as this approach appears to predict that such an order should be grammatical, contrary to fact. See the Finnish example in (31) below (cf. Holmberg 2000). While all other orderings are possible (cf. (31a) - (31c)), the V-O-Aux order is bad, as in (31d). We know that this structure is among the earliest presented evidence for the postulation of FOFC. So, accounting for its unavailability is important.

(31) **No V O Aux in Finnish** (Holmberg 2000, p.125)

a. Milloin Jussi [$_{\text{AuxP}}$ olisi [$_{\text{VP}}$ krijoittanut romaanin]]?
when Jussi AUX written novel
'When would Jussi have written a novel?' [Aux [V O]]

[19]For instance, Zeijlstra's (2023) analysis hinges on inflectional morphology, which may license head movement. And whenever we encounter a FOFC-violating structure, this must be a case whereby the higher head, which is head-final, is morpho-phonologically independent. Thus, such a head is not a movement target for a lower head. Ìkálẹ̀'s clause-final focus marker *rín* does not have any inflectional morphology as well. Therefore, we may say that it is not a movement target, and as a result a FOFC-violating structure.

[20]I thank an anonymous reviewer for highlighting this part.

b. Milloin Jussi $[_{\text{AuxP}}$ olisi $[_{\text{VP}}$ romaanin krijoittanut]]?
when Jussi AUX novel written
'When would Jussi have written a novel?' [Aux [O V]]

c. Milloin Jussi $[_{\text{AuxP}}$ $[_{\text{VP}}$ romaanin krijoittanut] olisi]?
when Jussi novel written AUX
'When would Jussi have written a novel?' [[O V] Aux]

d. *Milloin Jussi $[_{\text{AuxP}}$ $[_{\text{VP}}$ krijoittanut romaanin] olisi]?
when Jussi written novel AUX
'When would Jussi have written a novel?' *[[V O] Aux]

Let's make the issue more explicit. If we assume that CP and vP are phases, in V-O-Aux order, we have a situation whereby the verb is within a lower phase, vP, and the auxiliary is outside this lower phase, but within the higher phase, CP. The unavailability of V-O-Aux order would therefore suggests that FOFC holds across heads within different phases. We cannot explain the observed pattern (i.e., *V-O-Aux order) if FOFC holds separately within the lower Spell-Out domain and the higher Spell-Out domain. What we need is a mechanism that allows the Spell-Out FOFC domain to be shifted or extended in order to accommodate such data that do not violate FOFC (cf. den Dikken 2007, Gallego 2007, 2010).

A possible solution suggested by Erlewine (2017, 2023) relies on the morphological properties of the heads involved. The idea is that languages with verbal inflections usually require V-T movement, which may in turn extend the Spell-Out domain of the phase or even suspends it. The result is that the Aux and the verb in V-O-Aux are within a single Spell-Out domain. Therefore, the unavailability of the order obeys FOFC (see also Erlewine 2023). As a result, FOFC is predicted to be obeyed in languages that allows phase extension. On the other hand, languages with little or no verbal inflection, i.e., isolating languages, are predicted to allow the order V-O-Aux, thereby violating FOFC. This prediction appears to be on the right track as Philip (2013, p.206, citing Matthew Dryer, p.c.) notes that "for many of the VO languages exhibiting final uninflected tense or aspect particles, there is simply no verbal inflection in the language at all" (cf. Dryer 2007). As brought to Erlewine's notice by Jim Huang, the FOFC-violating V-O-Aux order is present in Middle Chinese and some Southeast Asian languages (see Erlewine 2017, p.69 and Simpson 2001), which are indeed isolating languages.

A second concern raised with the phase-based approach to FOFC has to do with the status of vP as a phase, which has come under some scrutiny of recent (see Keine 2020a,b, Grano and Lasnik 2018, Keine and Zeijlstra 2025, a.o.). However, there is a line of research that has argued for the validity of vP as a phase (see Abels 2012, Citko 2014, Georgi 2014, Van Urk and Richards 2015, Van Urk 2018, van Urk 2020a,b, a.o.). Moreover, to take this further, there are even studies, which assume a contextuality approach to what counts as a phase (cf. Bošković 2014, a.o.). So the disparity on whether vP is a phase or not does not hold much weight.

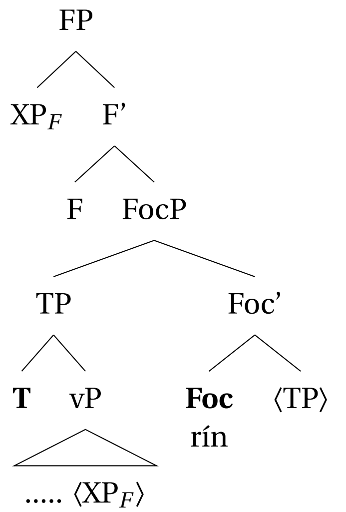
In the next section, I compare the structure that I proposed for ex-situ focus constructions in Ìkálẹ̀ in section 3 with anti-symmetric syntax. I argue against such an approach for ex-situ focus in Ìkálẹ̀.

5 Ex-situ focus structure and the anti-symmetric syntax

The structure that I proposed in (17) does not take the anti-symmetric approach to syntactic structure building into consideration. The assumption in the anti-symmetric theory of syntax is that all languages have an underlying Specifier-Head-Complement order (Kayne 1994). This means that languages are head-initial universally. The surface variation in word order that exists in the languages of the world is therefore a result of different movement steps. In this section, I provide two derivations for Ìkálẹ̀ ex-situ focus based on Kayne's (1994) anti-symmetry approach, and I show that they both come with a cost, and are therefore, not the best options (see also Aremu 2025, for a similar conclusion and a more elaborate discussion of the syntax of Ìkálẹ̀'s focus construction).

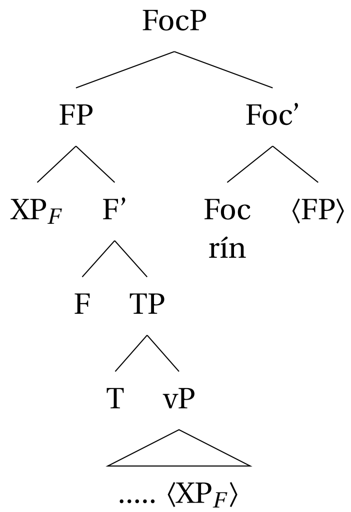
The first antisymmetry-compliant structure for ex-situ focus in Ìkálẹ̀ may look like (32). The focus phrase is head-initial with a TP complement which moves to the specifier of FocP. At this point of the derivation, the focus constituent (XP_F) is still in an in-situ position, and this does not result in the desired linearization. Since the normal position for the focus constituent (Spec,FocP) is occupied already, one option is to assume the presence of a functional projection (let's call this FP) above FocP whose Spec hosts the fronted focus constituent. This last movement of the focus to Spec,FP is theoretically surprising because it involves sub-extraction from a derived specifier (see Takita (2009), for a discussion of how this could be a problem cf. Huang (1982)).

(32) **Alternative structure one**



Alternatively, we might as well assume that the FP already projects above the TP, in order to hosts the internally-merged focus constituent in its specifier (Spec,FP), as in (33). Next, the focus phrase headed by a left-headed *rín* is merged. FP then moves to Spec,FocP in order to derive the correct linearization.

(33) **Alternative structure two**



These alternative (antisymmetry-compliant) derivations face at least three challenges. The first has to do with the nature and motivation of the projection, FP. Apart from providing a landing site for moved elements, there is no other motivation for FP. Assuming FP anytime there is a need for a landing position will only give room for unconstrained or unmotivated projections all over the place. Secondly, there is no (semantic or pragmatic) motivation for some of the movements in both structures. For example, in (32), the movement of TP to Spec,FocP does not correspond to the logical or semantic focus which normally moves to the same position in the left periphery. Additionally, the movement of the logical focus (XP_F) to Spec,FP would have to be motivated. The same thing can be said of the unmotivated movement steps in (33). A third challenge that the alternative structures pose is the violation of Comp-to-Spec Anti-locality Constraint, which disallows the movement of the complement of a head *x* to the specifier of *x* (Abels 2003). In other words, Comp-to-Spec anti-locality requires the movement of the complement of X to cross a head other than X itself. In (32), the movement of TP from Comp of FocP to Spec,FocP violates Comp-to-Spec anti-locality, and in (33), it is the movement of FP to Spec,FocP that violates Comp-to-Spec anti-locality.

Lastly, one of the major arguments for the anti-symmetric syntax is that movement are mostly to the left, and so, there is an asymmetry on whether movement can be to the left or right. However, much studies have shown that such an evidence does not hold much weight because the leftward property of movement (as against rightward movement) can be associated to structural parsing restrictions (cf. Gibson 1991, Frazier and Clifton 1996, Ackema and Neeleman 2002, Abels and Neeleman 2012, Zeijlstra 2023). Since sentences are usually uttered from left to right, elements that are moved leftward would already be pronounced even before getting to their trace position. However, a rightward-moved element might be difficult to parse because it is its trace that would be encountered first.[21] The speaker would have to alter the structure that he has already built. Thus, the asymmetry between leftward and rightward movements is more of a grammatical parsability issue than a purely syntactic issue (cf. Zeijlstra 2023).

6 Other clause-final focus marking languages

Based on the discussion so far, a cross-linguistic prediction is that the analysis in this study should be able to extend to other languages with clause-final morphological focus marking. Such languages would also exhibit what we might call apparently FOFC-violating structures. In this section, I discuss two of such languages: Igede and Nupe (both Benue-Congo, North-Central Nigeria), and also two other dialects of Yorùbá: Oǹdó and Òkìtìpupa (both Southeastern dialects of Yorùbá).

[21] While extraposition may initially appear to be a case of rightward movement, recent minimalist approaches have analyzed it using remnant movement (cf. Müller 1997, 1998, a.o.).

6.1 Two other dialects of Yorùbá

Two other closely related dialects of Yorùbá that also mark ex-situ focus clause-finally are Oǹdó and Òkìtìpupa. In fact, Oǹdó, Òkìtìpupa and Ìkálẹ̀ dialects are spoken in close proximity; in the same state, Oǹdó state, Nigeria. They share similar lexical items and structures. In Oǹdó dialect, the focus marker *ín* is realized clause-finally in both subject and object ex-situ focus constructions. See (34b) & (34c) respectively.

(34) **Oǹdó dialect of Yorùbá**

a. Tolú gbẹ̀n usu.
Tolu plant yam
'Tolú planted yam.'

b. [Tolú]$_F$ ó gbẹ̀n usu **ín**.
Tolu 3SG plant yam FOC
'TOLÚ planted yam.'

c. [Usu]$_F$ Tolú gbẹ̀n **ín**.
yam Tolu plant FOC
'Tolú planted YAM.´

(from Akintoye 2020, p.153)

The focus marker in Òkìtìpupa dialect of Yorùbá is also *ín*. Taking (35a) as the baseline, the examples in (35b), (35c) and (35d) show focus on the subject, the possessor, and the possessee respectively.[22]

(35) **Òkìtìpupa dialect of Yorùbá**

a. Ẹkùn ó mà iye Ṣadé.
tiger HTS know mother Ṣadé
'The tiger knew Ṣadé's mother.'

b. [Ẹkùn]$_F$ ó mà iye Ṣadé **ín**.
Tiger 3SG know mother Ṣadé FOC
'It was the tiger that knew Ṣadé's mother.'

c. [Ṣadé]$_F$ ẹkùn ó mà iye ẹ̀ **ín**.
Ṣadé tiger HTS know mother 3SG.POSS FOC
'It is Ṣadé whose mother the tiger knew.'

[22] Notice that there is a High Tone Syllable following the subject in all the examples except for example (35b) where it is functioning as a resumptive pronoun. There is a long line of the debate on the status of HTS and resumptive pronoun in the language. For example, Akintoye (2020) believes that it has a dual function in focus contexts where it functions both as an HTS and a resumptive pronoun. However, see Aremu (2024, §3.3) and Aremu (2025, §3.1.1) for a brief discussion on how the HTS should be treated as a floating high tone which undergoes a tonal sandhi with the high tone that is already present on the third person resumptive pronoun *ó* (see also Ilori 2010, Akintoye 2020, a.o.). For our purposes here, it does not play any significant role.

d. [Iye Ṣadé]$_F$ ẹkùn ó mà **ín**.
Mother Ṣadé tiger HTS know FOC
'It was Ṣadé's mother that the tiger knew.'

(from Akintoye 2020, p.151-152)

The two dialects of Yorùbá have an SVO word order. So, if the clause-final focus marker heads a FocP which in turn dominates a head initial TP, then this should result in a FOFC-violating structure based on the extended projection characterization of FOFC's domain. However, with the phase-based approach, the structure does not violate FOFC.

6.2 Two other clause-final focus marking languages

In Igede, the focus marker *lẹ̀* appears clause-finally, regardless of the category that is in focus. Consider the examples in (36), with the baseline sentence in (36a), and the ex-situ subject focus, direct object focus and DP-internal focus in (36b), (36c) & (36d) respectively.

(36) **Igede** (from Akintoye 2020, p.153, gloss adapted)

a. Ị̀jọ̀ jẹ́ ìnínà Iṣadé.
tiger know mother Ṣade's
'The tiger knows Ṣade's mother.'

b. [Ị̀jọ̀]$_F$ á jẹ́ ìnínà Iṣadé **lẹ̀**.
tiger 3SG know mother Ṣade's FOC
'THE TIGER knows Ṣade's mother.'

c. [Ìnínà Iṣadé]$_F$ ìjọ̀ jẹ́ **lẹ̀**.
mother Ṣade's tiger know FOC
'The tiger knows ṢADE'S MOTHER.'

d. [Iṣadé]$_F$ ìjọ̀ jẹ́ ìnínà àmụ̀ **lẹ̀**.
Ṣade's tiger know mother 3SG.POSS FOC
'The tiger knows ṢADE'S mother.'

Similarly, in Nupe, we have a *wh*-question context where the focus marker *o* also appears in the clause-final position. Both the ex-situ object *wh*-question and the ex-situ adjunct *wh*-question in (37a) and (37b) are obligatorily marked with a clause-final *o* respectively.

(37) **Ex-situ *wh*-questions in Nupe** (Mendes and Kandybowicz 2023, p.301)

a. **Ké** Musa pa ___ *(**o**)?
what Musa pound.PST FOC
'What did Musa pound?'

b. **Kánci** Musa pa eci ___ *(**o**)?
when Musa pound.PST yam FOC
'When did Musa pound the yam?'

That the focus marker *o* is clause-final is confirmed by the examples in (38). In these cases, *o* is 'distant from the trace of the *wh*-elements' (Mendes and Kandybowicz 2023, fn.1). The sentences involve local subject *wh*-question and embedded subject *wh*-question.

(38) **Matrix and embedded subject *wh*-questions in Nupe**

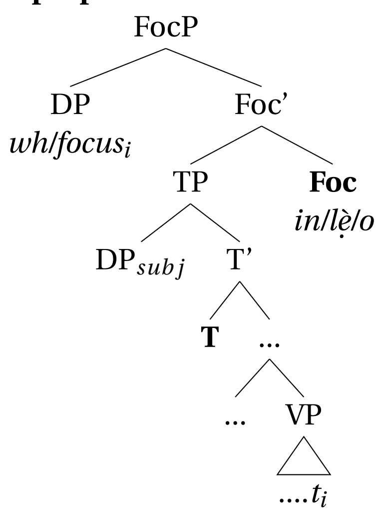
a. **Zě** á eci pa **o**?
who PFV yam pound.PST FOC
'Who has pounded the yam?'

b. **Zě** Gana gàn gànán *t* à du nakàn **o**?
who Gana say.PST COMP FUT cook meat FOC
'Who did Gana say will cook the meat?'

(Mendes and Kandybowicz 2023, fn.1)

Ignoring the possibility of other projections (like aspect phrase, vP, etc.) between TP and VP in these languages, I assume the following structure in (39); which is similar to what we proposed for Ìkálẹ̀ above (cf. (17))

(39) **A proposed structure for ex-situ focus in the four languages**



If we are right about the fact that the focus markers in Oǹdó, Òkìtìpupa, Igede, and Nupe occupy the head of FocP in the left periphery, then such a head dominating a head-initial TP should result in a FOFC-violating structure. However, considering our characterization of FOFC domain, which constrains the application of FOFC to spell-out domains, we end up with structures that are consistent with FOFC. In other words, the head of FocP is a part of the phase edge, and has the TP as its spell-out domain. This explains why a structure like (39) would not constitute a FOFC violation.

7 Conclusion

As more and more structures are analyzed with FOFC, the need for an adequate characterization of FOFC's domain also becomes important. In this paper, I have argued, using Ìkálẹ̀ (plus two other languages and two other dialects of Yorùbá), that SVO languages that morphologically mark ex-situ focus clause-finally are better accounted for using the spell-out characterization of FOFC's domain. Based on the structure that such languages present in ex-situ focus construction $[_{FocP}\ [_{TP}\ \mathbf{T}\ \mathrm{VP}]\ \mathbf{Foc}]$, it is hard to account for this FOFC-violating structure based on the extended projection's characterization of FOFC's domain. Furthermore, I discussed two alternative approaches to FOFC and its counterexamples, and highlight some challenges they face. For instance, I argued that, although classifying all FOFC-violating sentence-final particles as acategorial may appear convenient, it does not seem to be true. Some sentence-final particles, particularly the focus marker in Ìkálẹ̀ (and the other languages under study), appear to have selectional restrictions, and as such cannot be acategorial. Moreover, assuming a special treatment (i.e., exemption from FOFC) for such clause-final particles based on their unique properties does not make our theory explanatorily adequate. Therefore, I proposed that adopting a spell-out characterization of FOFC's domain of application helps us to account for what might even be seen as syncategorematic elements that project a functional phrase within the articulated CP periphery.

Acknowledgments

to be added ...

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